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Vibe Coded Website Report

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Vibe Coded Websites Report - Aftermark AI

Introduction

I spent weeks combing through more than 500 vibe coded websites across Reddit, Hacker News, Indie Hackers, Twitter threads, Product Hunt launches, and small personal sites built in the middle of the night.

Patterns repeat. Mistakes repeat. Aesthetic habits repeat.

This report documents every consistent marker that signals a website was coded fast, rushed, and guided more by vibes than intention. It is not a criticism. It is a source of awareness. Shipping fast is good, but shipping fast without clarity creates a very distinct look.

Use this report to avoid that look or lean into it intentionally.

SECTION 1. VISUAL RED FLAGS

These are the most common visual giveaways that instantly scream vibe coded.

1. The Signature Purple Problem

• Random purple gradient hero sections
• Neon purple text shadows
• Purple hover fills on buttons
• Purple glow drop shadows
• Purple accents even when the brand is not purple at all
• Purple on purple so nothing stands out

Purple is the unofficial mascot of vibe coded design.

2. Sparkle Icons Everywhere

The sparkle emoji or sparkle icon shows up in hero text, buttons, pricing cards, and even footers.
Example: “Launch your idea today ✨”

One sparkle is (maybe) fine. Twenty sparkles is a vibe coded diagnosis.

3. Hover Animations on Every Card

Hover effects are overused.
The big offenders:
• Cards lifting up aggressively
• Cards rotating slightly
• Cards moving a few pixels but breaking alignment
• Hover shadows that look like a flashlight under the mouse
• Buttons that bounce

Hover animations are fine when subtle. Vibe coded sites are never subtle.

4. Emojis used as UI elements

Emojis instead of icons.
Emojis inside headings.
Emojis on buttons.
Emojis in the footer.
Emojis as bullets in pricing tables.
Emoji overload is a key signal of rushed UI decisions.

5. Fake Testimonials

Huge vibe coded energy.
• Avatar looks AI generated
• Name is “Sarah P.”
• Quote is generic like “Helped me so much”
• No job title
• No link

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6. Social Icons that do nothing

Especially the Instagram icon that leads to “#”.
Or Twitter link goes to twitter.com.
Or LinkedIn opens a 404.
If a social icon is there only for decoration, it becomes a vibe coded tell.

7. Massive Icons with Tiny Text

The visual hierarchy looks inverted.
Huge 48px icon.
Text so small it feels like an afterthought.
This creates cheapness.

8. Generic Fonts With No Rhythm

Most vibe coded sites use:
• Inter
• Poppins
• Montserrat
• Roboto

Nothing wrong with the fonts, but the usage becomes vibe coded when:
• Heading weight is too thick
• Body text is too light
• Line height is inconsistent
• No spacing rhythm

Typography reveals whether thought went into the build.

9. Semi Transparent Headers

These show up everywhere.
Often combined with:
• Blur backgrounds
• Thin borders
• Low contrast text

It becomes a vibe coded tell when the transparency interacts poorly with scrolling content.

10. Bad Animations

• Lottie animations that do not match the brand
• Wiggle effects
• Bounce overshoot
• Cards popping into place with no easing
• Scroll animations that stutter
• Animations triggered too early

Bad animation is a dead giveaway of rushed builds.

SECTION 2. STRUCTURAL RED FLAGS

These are layout and UX issues that show up again and again.

1. No Loading States

A big one.
When you click something and nothing happens for seconds, the whole experience feels amateur.

Signs of missing loading states:
• Button stays the same during async actions
• No skeleton screens
• No progress indicator
• Empty white gaps while data loads

Even one loading indicator can fix this instantly.

2. Inconsistent Component Placement

Components move around from page to page.
• Button sizes change
• Padding changes

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3. Slow Server Actions

Pages hang.
Buttons freeze.
Animations lag.

Not a visual issue, but users feel it.
And when users feel it, the entire site gets labeled vibe coded.

4. Misaligned Grids

• Cards not aligned
• Uneven spacing
• Margins collapsing
• Sticky elements drifting out of position

One pixel misalignment can destroy the entire visual impression.

5. Too Many Different Border Radiuses

Huge giveaway.
• 4px here
• 12px there
• 32px buttons
• Circular avatars
• Square images

Inconsistent radiuses make everything look unintentional.

SECTION 3. CONTENT AND COPY RED FLAGS

Copywriting also gives away vibe coded builds.

1. Slightly Off Copyright Text

• “All right reversed”
• “Copyright 2024 YourSiteName”
• “Created by yourbrand”
• “Made by Me”

Looks small, but it signals lack of polish.

2. Meaningless Taglines

Examples I saw dozens of times:
• “Build your dreams”
• “Launch faster”
• “Create without limits”
• “Where ideas become reality”
• “The future of something”

These are filler phrases that make a website feel empty.

3. Overloaded Hero Sections

Everything thrown into one place:
• Sparkle
• Emoji
• Gradient
• Button
• Second button
• Animated card
• Microcopy
• Background image
• Shadow
• Lottie animation

Hero sections often look like everything was placed there in one sitting.

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1. Missing Meta Tags

• No OpenGraph image
• HTML title says “Home”
• No description

Instant vibe coded marker.

2. Broken Responsiveness

• Text overflowing
• Cards stacked weird
• Buttons too wide
• Layout collapsing on mobile

This was extremely common.

3. Non functional interactive elements

• Carousels that do not slide
• Tabs that do not tab
• Accordions that do not open
• Modals that never close
• Dark mode toggle that does nothing

When interactive elements do not respond, users assume vibe coded.

SECTION 5. VIBE CODED ENERGY CHECKLIST

A compressed master list you can use before shipping your site.

If you check 5 or more, your site probably looks vibe coded.

Brand and visuals:

• Purple gradient
• Sparkle emoji
• Hover animations everywhere
• Emojis in headings
• Fake testimonials
• Massive icons
• Generic font combos
• Semi transparent header
• Random border radiuses

UX and layout:

• Inconsistent components
• No loading state
• Misaligned grids
• Slow interactions
• Sticky header jitter
• Weird spacing rhythm

Technical:

• Missing OG image
• No favicon
• Non functional buttons
• Bad mobile layout
• Placeholder text left in

Copy:

• Generic taglines
• Slightly off copyright text
• Buzzword stacking
• No value proposition

SECTION 6. THE FIX: HOW TO REMOVE

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The core fixes

1. Establish a 4 or 8 point spacing system
2. Pick one font pair and stick to it
3. Standardize border radiuses
4. Remove most animations
5. Create one elevation style and reuse it
6. Fix responsiveness before polishing desktop
7. Add loading states everywhere
8. Tighten your copy to a single clear promise
9. Test every button, link, and social icon
10. Reduce visual novelty and increase clarity

The fastest way to make a site feel premium is consistency.

LLM Prompt

You are a senior product designer and front end engineer who specialises in clean, premium, intentional UI. Your job is to generate websites and components that never look vibe coded. Every output must show clarity, consistency, structure, and thoughtful design decisions. You should behave like someone who builds design systems for a living, not like someone generating a quick MVP.

Begin every project by establishing a strict spacing rhythm. Choose either a 4 point or 8 point scale and use it everywhere for margins, padding, and gaps. Never introduce random spacing values. A predictable rhythm is one of the clearest signals of polish, and rhythm breaks are one of the clearest signals of vibe coded work.

Typography must also follow a clear system. Select a single heading font and a single body font. Define a type ramp with consistent sizes and line heights, then apply it without improvisation. Headings should feel intentional and should follow a logical hierarchy. Body text should never be overly bold or overly light, and spacing between text blocks must be consistent across the entire site.

Color choices should always feel disciplined. Choose a small palette and stick to it. Avoid neon effects, avoid purple gradients unless the brand identity calls for it, and avoid any color usage that exists for novelty rather than purpose. Every accent should reinforce hierarchy, not distract from it. High contrast and readability is mandatory.

All components must come from a consistent design language. Buttons, cards, inputs, modals, and navigation elements must share the same border radius, shadow style, padding logic, and alignment patterns. Mixing styles or radiuses immediately creates a vibe coded feeling. Components should look like they belong together, even when used in different contexts.

Interactions and animations must be subtle and tied to user intent. Hover effects should never distort the layout or jump aggressively. Animation timing must feel natural. Never add movement purely for decoration and never allow interactions that behave unpredictably. Every interactive element must function properly. Buttons must respond. Tabs must switch. Accordions must open and close. Carousels must actually slide.

Layout should follow a proper grid. Content must align cleanly and consistently. Nothing should drift. Nothing should visually wobble. Sections should have breathing room. Containers should have predictable widths. Do not stack elements randomly or overuse centered content. Everything should feel balanced and structured.

Loading and async behaviour must be handled with care. Every interaction that triggers a delay should have a loading state. Buttons should visually shift into a loading indicator. Data heavy areas should use skeletons. Content should not appear suddenly with no transition. A site that feels alive and responsive always reads as more premium.

Copy must be specific and grounded. Avoid generic hero lines like “build your dreams” or “launch faster.” Speak clearly about what the product does and why it matters. Never rely on filler phrases. Testimonials must feel real. Footer text must be correct and professional. The tone should be confident but not exaggerated.

Technical fundamentals must be complete. Every output needs page titles, meta descriptions, OG images, functional social links, a favicon, and a layout that works as well on mobile as it does on desktop. Do not generate placeholders or half working links. Do not leave test text in the final layout. Ensure every element is usable and accessible.

You must actively identify and remove any element that signals vibe coded design. This includes sparkles, random emoji usage, purple gradients used without brand justification, fake testimonials, unintentional shadows, inconsistent spacing, mismatched radiuses, generic hero lines, broken responsiveness, missing loading states, and any animation that feels chaotic or unrefined. If you detect any of these issues, revise the output before presenting it.

The final result should feel like something shipped by a mature product team. It should demonstrate intention in every choice, clarity in every layout, and a calm, confident design